



Stress Less

Find calm in chaos



VALERIE MIRTO

As women in business, it's easy for us to fall into habits that drain our energy and push us toward burnout. The habitual way in which most of us operate when we're trying to be productive and impactful does not include the very things that will support us and sustain our output.

We may already know that taking steps to reduce stress is a good investment in our wellbeing, relationships, and success – but do we know where to start?

In **over** twenty years of coaching women, I have found that most of us have a much harder time stopping an old habit than adopting a new one. Stress Less is a tool designed to help you trade your current *depleting* habits for habits that renew personal energy and allow you to achieve — without burning out.

Ready to begin?

Simply follow this three-step plan to support improved success and wellbeing, *even under stress*.

Treat yourself beautifully,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Valerie". The script is fluid and cursive, with a large, sweeping initial "V".

Step 1: Take a few minutes to identify some of your habits and behaviors throughout a typical day or week. When feeling a sense of impending overwhelm, it's common for many of us to switch on autopilot and fall into familiar behaviors. This can happen whether or not those behaviors support us or work against us in the end.

The good news? Habits that ultimately drain you can be replaced by new habits that *replenish your energy and sustain your productivity and wellbeing.*

Look at the following **draining** habits and mark which ones are familiar to you. Then, use the remaining blank spaces to list additional draining habits that come to mind.

	Thinking of breaks and time-off as "rewards" you must "earn" with productivity and accomplishment.		Giving yourself a hard time about things that have already happened; dwelling on past mistakes.
	Having your lunch break at your desk in order to keep working.		
	Using a third or fourth cup of coffee to feel energized.		
	Racing through the day chasing your to-do lists.		
	Routinely skipping meals, sleep, or socializing in order to get more done.		
	Taking care of everything yourself at without asking for help.		
	Reacting to stressful events instantly rather than giving yourself a moment to choose a response.		
	Over-scheduling yourself every day.		
	Staying "on" and in work-mode 24/7 even when you're not in the office or on call.		
	Ignoring when your body tells you you're hungry, thirsty, or need a break.		

Step 2: Next, identify the habits and behaviors that you currently turn to that bring you energy and restore you. Unlike a quick caffeine fix that robs you of energy later in the day, habits like taking breaks, snacking on protein, and hydrating help you manage and sustain your energy as you move through the day.

Look at the following **replenishing** habits and mark which ones you already do in your life. Use the blank spaces that follow to list additional replenishing habits that support you.

	Step away from your work for a glass of water or a breath of fresh air.		Acknowledge and celebrate your successes, even small ones!
	Enjoy your lunch away from your work space in order to reset your brain.		
	Prioritize healthy boundaries.		
	Scheduling your time according to your energy levels throughout the day.		
	Increase self-care as challenges increase.		
	Clarify your true priorities on a daily and weekly basis.		
	Delegate tasks and ask for help.		
	Choose a mindful response rather than reacting immediately under stress.		
	Nurture your body with nutritious food, adequate rest, and time in nature.		
	Pause and step back for a fresh perspective.		
	Create "spaces in between" to regroup and reprioritize.		

Step 3: Look at your list of **draining** habits. Choose the **3 most draining habits** you experience in a typical day or week.

Then, choose **3 replenishing habits** to replace each of the three most draining ones you identified earlier.

Which replenishing habits feel easy? Which resonate with you the most? Imagine how each replenishing habit would feel if you reached for them instead.

Consider which new habit is appropriate for solving a problem that the depleting habit was trying to solve. If your depleting habit is trying to solve a physical issue (for example, fatigue) then trade it for a new habit that nurtures the physical body (for example, prioritizing a pause for some calming breaths in the middle of feeling overwhelmed). If your depleting habit drains you mentally or emotionally, try replacing it with something that reframes the situation, changes your mindset, or feels like it cultivates happiness or joy.

Top 3 Draining Habits

Top 3 Replenishing Habits

The foundation is laid. It's time to begin enjoying your new habits...

Time to make it effortless!

In order to support long term change, it works best to implement one new habit at a time.

Over the next week, practice implementing one of your new-and-improved habits. *Start strong by tackling your most draining habit first!*

Keep in mind that mistakes are always a part of the change process. Each time you find yourself behaving in the very ways you are trying to let go of, remember to offer yourself patience, and space to make mistakes. When you find yourself criticizing, making yourself wrong, or feeling frustrated; take a deep breath to reset the moment. Then, simply start again.

Don't be surprised if the first week feels the most challenging. Change is messy. Establishing new habits and using new tools to navigate stress takes time.

The secret is pairing self-compassion with persistence.

This tool is meant to be inserted into your real life. It may take a try or two (or three) before you have a solid week of practice — and that's okay! I recommend not moving on to the second and third habits until you've had a solid week of practice with your first habit.

While you may be used to going full steam ahead in all that you do, I want to reiterate the importance of pacing yourself in order to have long-term success adopting new behaviors. Over time, these new behaviors will become your go-to habits!

**Discover more Success Through Self-care™ tools and wisdom at
coachvalerie.com or [@lifecoachvalerie](https://www.instagram.com/lifecoachvalerie) on Instagram**



About Valerie



Valerie Mirto is a Transformational Coach, author, and entrepreneur specializing in Success Through Self-care™. She has over 20 years of experience helping women transform themselves personally and professionally to create the lives they imagine living. Her passion remains helping women create healthier, happier, more authentic, successful lives — *without trading what matters most.*

Her experience as a self-employed single-mother enables her to understand the challenges and tradeoffs that come with operating at full speed, while fending off overwhelm. Her programs and services are designed to support women in championing alignment, expanded thinking, and the incalculable value of treating themselves beautifully to counteract stress.



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